

YASBANT NEGI



TERROR FLIP-FLOP

During the debate on POTA, passed by the NDA Government in 2002, Sonia Gandhi had argued against the need for an anti-terror law saying, "We have enough special laws in the country... Any or all of these can be further strengthened and amended." So much for these famous last words. Six years later, with general elections round the corner, the Manmohan Singh government had no choice but to give in to the public outrage and bring in its own version of POTA, along with a stricter, sterner home minister. But is it too late? That is the Congress's biggest fear.

PANKAJ NANGIA

UNSAFE AT HOME

The former home minister had an unblemished track record of failure, yet **Shivraj Patil** carried on right till the bitter end. The Congress leadership was wary of nominating a strong man in the North Block, and so Patil carried on, wearing his incompetence on his sleeve.



BHASKAR PAUL



QUIT PRO QUO

Soon after the Mumbai massacre, the Congress dithered over the resignation of Vilasrao Deshmukh, the then Maharashtra chief minister until Sharad Pawar forced its hand. In a swift midnight decision, he asked the home minister and NCP's R.R. Patil to resign, forcing the Congress to follow suit with Deshmukh's resignation. No wonder, the Congress leadership has a healthy distrust of the shrewd Maratha.

MAYA'S NEW SUITORS

Mayawati's unshackled ambition to be the prime minister has both the Congress and the BJP worried. She, in turn, is not too happy with the Congress and the SP alliance. However, Mayawati has found support in the born-again Third Front led by the communists. Fearful of becoming irrelevant after it withdrew support to the UPA, the Left is seeking unnatural allies. Despite his reservations against caste politics, Prakash Karat backs Mayawati as the next PM.

■ Compiled by **Priya Sahgal**

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